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ACCOUNTING FOR EPISTEMIC RELEVANCE: A NEW PROBLEM FOR THE CAUSAL THEORY OF MEMORY

Dorothea Debus

In their paper “Remembering,” first published in the *Philosophical Review* in 1966, Martin and Deutscher develop what has since come to be known as the Causal Theory of Memory. The core claim of the Causal Theory of Memory (as formulated by Martin and Deutscher) runs as follows:

If someone remembers something, whether it be “public,” such as a car accident, or “private,” such as an itch, then the following criteria must be fulfilled:

1. Within certain limits of accuracy he represents that past thing.
2. If the thing was “public,” then he observed what he now represents. If the thing was “private,” then it was his.
3. His past experience of the thing was operative in producing a state or successive states in him finally operative in producing his representation. These three statements express the condition which we consider to be separately necessary and jointly sufficient, if an event is to be an instance of remembering.¹

The Causal Theory of Memory is very attractive, and although Martin and Deutscher’s formulation of it was published in 1966, the Causal Theory permeates and informs philosophical and psychological work on memory to this day.² Usually, philosophical discussion of the Causal Theory of Memory in general (and Martin and Deutscher’s definition of

memory in particular) centers around the question whether the three conditions offered here are indeed *necessary* for an event to be an instance of remembering. More specifically, opponents often object that the Causal Theory’s third condition, the causal condition, is not necessary in order for an event to be an instance of remembering.³ Other philosophers think that the causal condition is a particularly appealing aspect of the account.⁴ Empirical psychologists, on the other hand, often simply rely on the Causal Theory of Memory without any further argument. That is, empirical psychologists often assume that conditions of the kind formulated by Martin and Deutscher are indeed necessary and sufficient for an event to count as an instance of remembering.⁵

For present purposes, we might grant that all three of the Causal Theory’s conditions are *necessary* for an event to count as an instance of remembering. However, so I hope to show in the present paper, in some relevant cases, namely, cases of experiential memory, at least one further condition, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition, needs to be met in order for a relevant experience to count as an instance of remembering. This implies that for at least some events (namely, the occurrence of certain experiences), the Causal Theory’s three conditions are not jointly sufficient for the relevant events to count as instances of remembering.

Of course, one might reject the Causal-Theory's Sufficiency-Claim for various reasons.⁶ The present paper offers one such reason, as it seems new and important for rejecting the Causal Theory's Sufficiency-Claim, namely, the need for the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition. Coming to see that the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition needs to be met in order for a present experience to count as an instance of remembering should in turn further our understanding of the phenomenon of experiential memory.

I.

In an attempt to assess the Causal Theory's Sufficiency-Claim, one might begin by asking why anybody might want to endorse that claim. Surprisingly, Martin and Deutscher themselves do not offer any explicit argument in support of their Sufficiency-Claim. Rather, they simply consider various counterexamples to the claim that their three conditions are sufficient for an event to count as an instance of remembering,⁷ then argue that the relevant examples should not count as counterexamples, and conclude:

We can offer no argument for the sufficiency of our list of criteria other than the failure, after examination of cases, to find the need for a longer list.⁸

Curiously, however, Martin and Deutscher themselves do, in rejecting one counterexample to their Sufficiency-Claim, introduce an example which, if reconsidered, might in fact point toward the need for a longer list. The relevant example runs as follows:

(The Painter) Suppose that someone asks a painter to paint an imaginary scene. The painter agrees to do this and, taking himself to be painting some purely imaginary scene, paints a detailed picture of a farmyard, including a certain colored and shaped house, various people with detailed features, particular items of clothing, and so on. His parents then recognize the picture as a very accurate representation

of a scene which the painter saw just once in his childhood. The figures and colors are as the painter saw them only once on the farm which he now depicts. We may add more and more evidence to force the conclusion that the painter did his work by no mere accident. . . . [Nevertheless,] the painter sincerely believes that his work is purely imaginary, and represents no real scene.⁹

How could we possibly explain what happens to the painter here? On Martin and Deutscher's account, the case should clearly count as a case of memory. And indeed, Martin and Deutscher interpret the case as follows:

Although the painter sincerely believes that his work is purely imaginary, and represents no real scene, the amazed observers have all the evidence needed to establish that in fact he is remembering a scene from childhood. What other explanation could there be for his painting being so like what he has seen?¹⁰

As a matter of fact, so Martin and Deutscher hold,

the onlookers [are] compelled to the conclusion that the painter [is] remembering something he saw in childhood. It would [be] unreasonable for them to think that he would [do] what he [does] if it [was not] for some particular past observation. . . . [In the case described,] the only reasonable explanation of the fact that the painter put[s] details, colors, people, and so on into his picture, just as he saw them only once in his childhood, is that he [is] remembering that scene from his childhood.¹¹

Now, it might indeed be unreasonable for the onlookers to think that the painter would do what he does were it not for some particular past observation. Thus, we might grant that it seems plausible to say that the painting is somehow causally dependent on the painter's relevant childhood experiences. But this does not yet entail that the painter is presently *remembering* the scene he observed in his childhood, as Martin and Deutscher claim. For "why say that the painter *remembers*

the scene at all?"¹² Unless we *presuppose* that the Causal Theory's three conditions are sufficient in order for an event to count as an instance of remembering, it does not seem obvious at all that we should say that the painter remembers the scene. Nor do we need to assume this in order to explain the situation, as Martin and Deutscher intimate. Rather, it seems possible and perfectly reasonable to explain the situation by holding that there is *some causal connection* between the painter's past experiences and his present painting, while one might at the same time perfectly reasonably *deny* that the painter remembers anything. However, on Martin and Deutscher's account, we seem forced to say that the painter's case is a case of memory. As this does not seem obviously so, we can conclude that Martin and Deutscher's own example of the painter gives us reason to doubt their Sufficiency-Claim.

The following example, originally offered by Norman Malcolm, throws further doubt on that claim:

(The Green Van) A man recurrently has certain visual experiences. Sometimes, so this man claims, "he sees very clearly in his mind three men in black masks who seize him and carry him to a green automobile. Let us suppose that he was kidnapped when a small boy, by three men in black masks who had a green automobile."¹³ Thus, suppose the man's present visual experience of a green van is similar to a relevant perceptual experience of a green van which he had in the original situation. Furthermore, the man's present visual experience of a green van causally depends on information which was encoded while the relevant past perceptual experience of a green van occurred, and which has somehow been preserved since then.

According to the Causal Theory of Memory, our assessment of the present case should be clear. The case of the man and the green van should obviously count as a case of memory. Our own everyday intuitions, however, seem

to be fuzzy here. Considered from an everyday point of view, it certainly does not seem *obvious* that the experience as described by Malcolm should count as a memory. Indeed, it seems plausible to hold with Malcolm that on the basis of our everyday intuitions, it seems neither clearly right to say that the subject remembers the green van and the three men in black masks nor does it seem clearly right to say he does not remember them.¹⁴ Thus, our intuitions are not clearly in line with the Causal-Theory's Sufficiency-Claim. Once more, therefore, we find that we have reason to *doubt* the Sufficiency-Claim.¹⁵

II.

Moreover, we have good reason to *reject* the Sufficiency-Claim, for we have good reason to deny that cases like the case of the Green Van should count as instances of remembering. The following two sections aim to support this claim.

As indicated in the previous section, our intuitions about whether or not the case of the Green Van should count as an instance of remembering diverge. We might therefore simply agree that it is impossible to determine whether or not this and similar cases should count as instances of remembering. This, however, would immediately imply that Martin and Deutscher's Sufficiency-Claim is wrong. After all, according to the Sufficiency-Claim, it is possible to give a clear answer to the question whether relevant cases should count as instances of remembering.

Thus, if we want to avoid the immediate defeat of the Sufficiency-Claim, we should make a reasoned choice as to whether or not the case of the Green Van should count as an instance of remembering. So far we have not been given any good reason in favor of holding that this and similar cases should count as instances of remembering, and the following considerations will show that we have good reason against doing so.

The man described in the case of the Green Van is reported to “see things in his mind,” to have certain recurrent visual experiences. We might have doubts as to whether the experiences described in the case of the Green Van should count as memories, but we all know of other cases in which subjects have experiences which should, in turn, quite uncontroversially count as memories. For example, try to remember the last dinner party you went to. Chances are that you remember at least some aspects of the event in an experiential way. You might have an experience as if seeing again the host welcoming you at the door. Or you might have an experience as if hearing once more some particular sounds or noises—the sudden bang emanating from the kitchen at some point or a new tune played toward the end of the party. In an attempt to describe those occurrences, we might say that “you see the person again in front of your mind’s eye,” that you can “hear the tune in your head again,” and so on for the other senses. The relevant experiential memories are cases of remembering which characteristically “correspond to our use of the distinct senses,”¹⁶ and we all seem to have such experiential memories on a daily basis.¹⁷

What is more, experiential memories usually also play a role in our forming judgements about the past. Indeed, experiential memories usually have “epistemic relevance” for a subject when she makes judgements about the past. For example,

(Emma’s Case) consider Emma who is asked by a colleague whether Mary attended her lecture yesterday. During the lecture, Emma did not form any particular belief about Mary at all, and she does not have any beliefs about Mary’s presence or absence, but prompted by the colleague’s question, she visually remembers Mary sitting in the left back corner of the room during yesterday’s lecture. On the basis of her experiential memory, Emma is able to tell that Mary did attend the lecture.¹⁸

So it seems plausible to hold that experiential memories usually do have “epistemic relevance” for a subject—that is, the subject takes them into account when making judgements about the past. A present experience has epistemic relevance for a subject who makes a judgement about the past if the subject’s judgement about the past is, from the subject’s own point of view, in some way supported by the relevant event. Thus, an experience has “epistemic relevance” for a subject in judging about the past if the subject takes the relevant experience into account when judging about the past, that is, if she treats the relevant experience as providing her with reasons to judge about the past in certain and not in other ways.

An experience might have epistemic relevance for a subject in judging about the past in various different ways. First, the relevant experience might reconfirm a belief about the past which the subject already has. Thus, for example, Anna might presently have a vivid visual experience of meeting Paul, which might reconfirm her in the belief that she met Paul yesterday. Second, a relevant present experience has epistemic relevance for the subject in judging about the past if it makes her reconsider a belief which she has held so far. Such a reconsideration might be necessary if the subject realizes a contradiction between her present experience and the content of other beliefs she endorses. For example, Anna might believe that she spent all day in the library yesterday, but then she vividly remembers meeting Paul in a café, which makes her reconsider that belief. In those cases, the relevant present experience is epistemically relevant for the subject in judging about the past in a negative way. It prompts the subject to reconsider whether certain beliefs which she has so far unquestioningly endorsed might have to be discarded as false. Third, a present experience might have epistemic relevance for a subject in judging about the past because it provides the

subject with new knowledge about the past, as illustrated by Emma's case above. Emma has an experiential memory of Mary, and on the basis of the relevant present experiential memory, Emma forms the judgement that Mary did attend yesterday's lecture.

In summary, then, we can say that

(Epistemic Relevance) an experience has epistemic relevance for a subject who makes judgements about the past if the subject is disposed to take the relevant experience into account when judging about the past. When a subject takes a relevant experience into account when judging about the past, the experience might give the subject reason to form a new belief about the past, the experience might give the subject a further reason to endorse a belief which she already has about the past, or the experience might give the subject reason to critically reconsider (and maybe discard) certain beliefs which she has so far endorsed about the past.¹⁹

III.

But then, so I would like to suggest,

(Epistemic-Relevance-Condition) in order for an experience to count as an instance of remembering, it is *necessary* that the relevant experience have epistemic relevance for the subject when judging about the past; that is, it is necessary that the subject be disposed to take the relevant experience into account when judging about the past.

In order to see why we should accept the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition, we might consider the following example: Apart from certain oddities which we will describe in a moment, John has a very normal and average psychological life. In particular, he has all sorts of beliefs about past objects and events, some of which he witnessed himself. He also frequently has experiences which present him with objects and events which he encountered in the past. Sometimes the content of the relevant experiences is related to the content of some of the beliefs about the

past which John endorses. However, John is never disposed to make any epistemological use of those experiences that present him with objects and events which he encountered in the past. Indeed, he is never aware of the fact that the relevant experiences present him with objects or events which he encountered in the past, and he is never aware of the fact that he has reason to take the relevant experiences into account when judging about the past. He is oblivious to the fact that he might use the relevant experiences in support of the beliefs which he already holds about the past, and he is similarly oblivious to the fact that the relevant experiences sometimes provide him with a good reason to form certain new beliefs about the past. At no point is John disposed to make any epistemological use of the relevant experiences. Thus, as far as John's judgements about the past are concerned, these experiences simply do not play any role whatsoever. What is more, in situations in which the content of one of his beliefs about the past stands in outright contradiction to the content of one of the relevant experiences, he is not puzzled in the slightest. Such contradictions never prompt him to reconsider the accuracy of a relevant belief (let alone the accuracy of the relevant experience). When making judgements about the past, he will unhesitatingly stick to how things are presented to him in his beliefs about the past. Clearly, then, John is not in any way disposed to make any epistemological use of the relevant experiences, and he is unaware of the fact that he has reason to take the relevant events into account when judging about the past. In this respect, John's psychological life is importantly different from a normal subject's psychological life.

The difference between John's mental life and a "normal" subject's mental life might be illustrated as follows: Assume that both John and Mary, a "normal" subject, have been at a dinner party recently. Thinking about the dinner party now, Mary has certain beliefs

about it and experiential memories of it. John similarly has certain beliefs, and he also has certain experiences which present him with certain states of affairs and events which he observed at the time. Now, let us assume that both John and Mary have experiences which present them with the guests, all seated around the table. Neither John nor Mary have so far formed any beliefs about how many people were at the dinner party or whether any of them wore a red top. When asked, "Did anybody wear a red top?" or "How many people were there?" Mary will make use of her experiential memories of the people around the table and will answer the questions on this basis. Furthermore, she will be aware of the fact that her experiential memory of the people around the table gives her a *reason* to make the relevant judgements. John, on the other hand, has an experience which presents him with everybody around the table, but he is unaware of the fact that he has reason to take his experience into account when forming a judgement about whether anybody was wearing a red top or how many people were there. Although John's experiences present him with the relevant information, and although the relevant experiences occur in a context of other beliefs about the dinner party, John is unaware of the fact that the experiences give him a reason to hold that, say, ten people had dinner together that night and that no one was wearing a red top. John's present visual experience of the people around the dinner table is therefore nothing but a free-floating, "dangling" element in John's psychological life. The experience occurs, but John does not take it into account when thinking about the past event at all. What is more, John's present situation is not exceptional. In each and every analogous case, John will be similarly unaware of the fact that he has reason to take the relevant experiences into account when trying to answer analogous questions.

It seems that in situations like the one described, the difference between a subject

who is and a subject who is not aware of the fact that she has reason to take the relevant experiences into account when judging about the past is considerable. Mary is able to form reasonable new beliefs about the past. John, on the other hand, will not do so. A subject like John, who has certain experiences which present past events to him, but who is never aware of the fact that he has reason to take those experiences into account when judging about the past, might be said to have *some* kind of ability. Clearly, such a subject has the ability to be aware of past events experientially. However, this ability seems very different from the abilities of "normal subjects" such as Mary.

The difference between the mental lives of both subjects seems rather deep. Indeed, the difference seems so deep that we might plausibly mark it by holding that the relevant events in Mary's mental life should, while the relevant events in John's mental life should not, count as memories. But then, as we have seen, what distinguishes Mary's mental life from John's is that relevant events in Mary's mental life have epistemic relevance for Mary when she makes judgements about the past, whereas relevant events in John's mental life do not have any epistemic relevance for John when he makes judgements about the past. If we combine this insight with the claim that Mary's relevant experiences should, while John's relevant experiences should not, count as memories, we then also have good reason to endorse the more general conclusion that

(Epistemic-Relevance-Condition) in order for an experience to count as an instance of remembering, it is *necessary* that the relevant experience have epistemic relevance for the subject when judging about the past; that is, it is necessary that the subject be disposed to take the relevant experience into account when judging about the past.

Note that the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition does leave room for exceptional cases in

which the subject has an experience which should count as a memory, even though the subject refrains from basing any judgements about the past on the relevant experience. The Epistemic-Relevance-Condition only demands that in order for the experience to count as a memory experience, the subject should be *disposed* to make epistemological use of the relevant experience. However, the subject might then refrain from doing so, if she has good reasons not to do so (such as, for example, the knowledge that she is often prone to *misremember* things) which outweigh her original disposition to make epistemological use of the relevant experience. John, however, does not meet the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition because he is not even *disposed* to make epistemological use of the relevant experiences. Cases like that of the Green Van do not meet the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition for the same reason. But then, as we have reason to accept the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition, we can conclude that those cases should not count as instances of remembering. More generally, we find that the three conditions offered by the defender of the Causal Theory of Memory are *not* jointly sufficient for an event to count as an instance of remembering. Rather, in order for a present experience to count as a case of memory, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition must also be met.²⁰

IV.

However, so an opponent might object, our present argument in support of the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition relies on a simple *stipulation*. We stipulate that we do not want to call John's experiences "memories," which then leads us to formulate the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition. On the other hand, so the opponent points out, we originally set out to understand what remembering *is*. "But how could a mere stipulation ever address any serious concern of this nature?"²¹ Stipulations, so the opponent will say, are "arbitrary

and therefore theoretically irrelevant; they are merely devices for saving ink."²² Accordingly, as the present argument in support of the Epistemic-Relevance-Claim relies on a stipulation, we really have no good reason to accept the Epistemic-Relevance-Claim at all.

In reply, we should note that the stipulation involved in our present considerations is *not* arbitrary, as the opponent intimates. On the contrary, we have a rather good reason for stipulating that John's experiences should not count as instances of remembering. As we saw, the role which John's experiences play in his mental life are very different from the role that Mary's analogous experiences play in her mental life, and we try to mark this difference by stipulating that Mary's experiences should count as instances of remembering, while John's experiences should not. The present stipulation, therefore, certainly is not arbitrary. Neither is it, as the opponent claims, "theoretically irrelevant." On the contrary, we are trying to understand the phenomenon of memory, and our present stipulation implies that only events which have *epistemic relevance* for the subject should count as instances of remembering. The present stipulation, therefore, furthers our understanding of the question which the opponent wants us to address, namely the question what remembering is. Thus, our stipulation is not "theoretically irrelevant."²³

Nevertheless, so the opponent might insist, while John's and Mary's experiences differ in a certain respect, they are similar in other respects. Indeed, someone might claim that both Mary's and John's relevant experiences fulfill each of the three conditions listed by the Causal Theory of Memory and that they are similar in that respect. But then, so the opponent might argue, given this similarity, and given that Mary's relevant experiences should count as instances of remembering, John's experiences should also count as instances of remembering. However, if John's experiences *are* instances of remembering, the Epistemic-

Relevance-Condition is false, and accordingly, so the opponent concludes, we should give up on the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition.

Clearly, the present objection hinges on how much weight we give to the similarities on the one hand and to the dissimilarities on the other, between John's and Mary's relevant experiences. Our everyday concept of memory does seem to imply that memories should have some epistemic relevance for the remembering subject. Indeed, it seems a deeply entrenched part of our everyday way of thinking about memory that memories play an important role in our forming judgements about the past, and that memories therefore should have "epistemic relevance" for a subject when she makes judgements about the past.²⁴ We might bring this out further with the help of the following example:

(Lucy's Memory of the Blue Car) Lucy presently has *an experience* of a *bright* blue car moving toward her, and she takes this experience to be presenting her with an event which she witnessed in the past. When Lucy is given a set of color patches and is asked to choose the color sample which most resembles the color which her present experience presents the car as having had, she picks a bright blue color patch. Lucy also has a full grasp of the color concepts, and in particular, she is well able to distinguish bright blue and dark blue color patches. Nevertheless, speaking about the relevant past event, Lucy *judges*: "At the time, I saw a *dark* blue car approaching."

Clearly, there is an inconsistency between Lucy's present experience on the one hand, and her judgement about her past experience on the other. There seem to be different ways to deal with this inconsistency: We might either think that while Lucy does in fact experientially remember the past experience, her judgement about the past experience is *wrong*, and she should therefore suspend judgement. Alternatively, we might take Lucy's judgement to be true but doubt that her present experience should count as a memory.

Or, finally, we might look for some special explanation of why Lucy's experience *should* count as a memory of the past experience and why, at the same time, her judgement should also be true.²⁵ However, we will think Lucy to be irrational and might start worrying about her state of mind if she continues to hold that her present experience of a bright blue car approaching refers to the relevant past event and if she at the same time *also* adheres to the judgement that the relevant car was dark blue and that she perceived a dark blue car approaching at the time *without* any further explanation. This, in turn, indicates that it is indeed deeply entrenched in our everyday way of thinking about memory that memories play an important role in our forming judgements about the past, and that memories therefore should have "epistemic relevance" for a subject when she makes judgements about the past.

With respect to our earlier case of John and Mary, it might therefore also seem rather plausible to try to preserve the idea that memories play an important role in our forming judgements about the past. We can do this by taking the dissimilarities between John's and Mary's respective experiences seriously and by stipulating that John's experiences should not count as instances of remembering.

However, if the opponent continues to insist on giving more weight to the *similarities* between both kinds of experiences, it seems that there is not much we can do to stop her from doing so. In this case, we will just have to let her hold that both Mary's and John's relevant experiences should count as instances of remembering. Most certainly, however, John's experiences are not *paradigmatic* cases of remembering, and even the stubborn opponent will have to agree with that. Mary's experiential memories, on the other hand, might well count as paradigmatic cases of remembering. Thus, even if the stubborn opponent refuses to accept our earlier

Epistemic-Relevance-Condition, she will still have to agree with the following:

(Modified-Epistemic-Relevance-Condition)

In order for an experience to count as a *paradigmatic* instance of experiential memory, it is necessary that the relevant experience have epistemic relevance for the subject when judging about the past; that is, it is necessary that the subject be disposed to take the relevant experience into account when judging about the past.

The Modified-Epistemic-Relevance-Condition leaves room for the stubborn opponent's claim that even cases such as that of the Green Van might count as instances of remembering. However, even the stubborn opponent will have to agree that those cases are certainly not *paradigmatic* instances of remembering, and the Modified Epistemic-Relevance-Condition explains why not. Thus, even our opponent should gain something from our present considerations. For even if she continues to deny that the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition needs to be met in order for an experience to count as an instance of remembering *tout court*, she must agree that the Modified-Epistemic-Relevance-Condition has to be met in order for an experience to count as a *paradigmatic* instance of remembering. Thus, even the stubborn opponent will, on the basis of our present considerations, have to conclude that the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition is worth taking seriously.

However, most of us will not be quite as stubborn as the stubborn opponent. Thus, most will, so I hope, share the intuition that we should give more weight to the *dissimilarities* between John's and Mary's respective experiences than to the relevant similarities, and that we therefore have good reason to stipulate that while Mary's experiences are instances of remembering, John's are not. If we grant this, so we have seen, we also have good reason to endorse the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition and hold that

(Epistemic-Relevance-Condition) in order for an experience to count as an instance of remembering, it is *necessary* that the relevant experience have epistemic relevance for the subject when judging about the past; that is, it is necessary that the subject be disposed to take the relevant experience into account when judging about the past.

This in turn implies that the three conditions offered by the defender of the Causal Theory of Memory are *not* jointly sufficient for an experience to count as an instance of remembering; that is, at least with respect to experiential memories, Martin and Deutscher's Sufficiency-Claim is false. In order for an experience to count as a memory, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition must also be met.²⁶

This might, in turn, pose a challenge for scientific accounts of memory. For the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition demands that in order for a certain event to count as an instance of remembering, the subject has to be able to take the relevant event into account when judging about the past. Thus, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition demands that there be a reason-giving relation between the relevant event and the subject's judgement. But then, so one might hold, such normative, reason-giving relations are "anomalous," whereas the natural sciences can only account for nomic relations.²⁷ The Epistemic-Relevance-Condition therefore poses a serious problem for any attempt to account fully for the phenomenon of remembering with the help of the natural sciences alone.

Of course, the present argument and its conclusion are controversial, and various replies might be developed on behalf of those who hope to be able to offer a complete account of the phenomenon of remembering with the help of the natural sciences one day. However, it seems important to note that once we do accept that the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition needs to be met in order for a certain event to count as a case of memory, those who want

to defend a scientific account of the phenomenon of remembering will have to show that, and how, it is possible to offer an account of normative relations in scientific terms.

For the time being we can conclude that in order for an experience to count as a case of memory, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition needs to be met. And even the stubborn opponent will have to grant that in order for an experience to count as a *paradigmatic* case of remembering, the Modified-Epistemic-

Relevance-Condition needs to be met. Either way, therefore, we can conclude that the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition describes a very important feature of those experiences which are cases of memory. Thus, *pace* Martin and Deutscher and other defenders of the Causal Theory of Memory, an appropriate account of experiential memory has to accommodate the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition.

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NOTES

1. Martin and Deutscher 1966, p. 166.
2. Thus, for example, in an anthology collecting landmark epistemological papers written during the second half of the twentieth century, Bernecker and Dretske 1999 reprint Martin and Deutscher's paper as the only one on memory.
3. Cf., e.g., Malcolm 1963, Squires 1969, Lewis 1983, and Rundle 1986. Indeed, at the time at which Martin and Deutscher's paper was published, the view that the causal condition was *not* a necessary condition for memory was fairly widespread, which might explain (at least partly) why Martin and Deutscher's paper came to such prominence.
4. Most of those who deny that Martin and Deutscher's third condition is a *necessary* condition for memory are arguably driven by "anti-Cartesianism" and by what Child 1994 calls "interpretationism," namely the view that we can only understand our mental lives "by reflection on the procedure for *interpreting* a subject's attitudes and language" (Child 1994, p. 1). However, as Child 1994 shows, an anti-Cartesian stance and interpretationism are *compatible* with an attempt to "think about the mental in causal terms" (Child 1994, p. 119).
5. For a survey of some of the relevant research, see Brown and Craik 2000; see also Sutton 1998.
6. One might, for example, point out that the Causal Theory's conditions as stated so far do not, as they should, exclude cases in which a *deviant* causal chain obtains between a certain past event and a relevant present event. Indeed, Martin and Deutscher 1966 (pp. 180ff.) do discuss the possibility of deviant causal chains in detail. They suggest that "the problem can be solved by recourse to the idea of a memory trace" (p.189), and they accordingly add an appropriate subclause to their third condition. Owens 1992 (pp. 158–162), who discusses the Causal Theory of Memory in the context of a broader discussion of the problem of deviant causal chains, argues that we should accept Martin and Deutscher's solution. Others, e.g., Bennett and Hacker 2003 (sec. 5.22, "Storage, Retention and Memory Traces"), have been less favorable to the idea that memory requires the preservation of certain "memory traces." For a detailed discussion of the idea of memory traces, see also Bernecker 2001.
7. Cf. Martin and Deutscher 1966, pp. 166–172.
8. *Ibid.*, p. 172.
9. *Ibid.*, p. 168.
10. *Ibid.*
11. *Ibid.*, pp. 175ff.

12. Lewis 1983, p. 25.

13. Malcolm 1963, p. 213.

14. Cf. *ibid.*, 213.

15. Note that Malcolm (*ibid.*, pp.212ff.), uses the example of the Green Van for a different purpose. Malcolm considers it as a possible counterexample to his claim that perceptual memory depends on factual memory, and holds that his claim remains untouched by the alleged counterexample.

16. Martin 2002, p. 403. In the passage from which the present quote is taken, Martin explains what he means by “sensory imagining”: “By sensory imagining I have in mind those distinctive episodes of imagining or imaging which correspond to our use of the distinct senses: so we talk of visualising corresponding to seeing, or listening in one’s head parallel to audition, and so on.” The phenomenon of experiential memory, so it seems, can be introduced in perfectly analogous ways. An account of the *nature* of experiential memory, however, is bound to differ in important respects from an account of the nature of sensory imagining. There is no time to discuss the relevant differences here, but I do so in Debus (manuscript) and Debus (2008). The difference between experiential memory and sensory imagination is also addressed by Hume 1978, I.i.3, I.iii.5, Appendix pp. 627ff.; Russell 1989 (Lecture IX, “Memory,” esp. pp. 176–187); and Urmson 1967, p. 90.

17. Philosophers usually distinguish between “factual” and “experiential” memories. As Owens 1996, p. 320n3, points out, “the philosopher’s distinction [between factual and experiential memories] goes back at least to H. Bergson”; cf. Bergson 1991, chap. 2. Further points of reference for the distinction between factual and experiential memory (also mentioned by Owens *loc. cit.*) are Russell 1989; Ayer 1956 chap. 4; Malcolm 1963; and Martin and Deutscher 1966; Owens 1996, pp.320–21, himself offers further helpful comments on the distinction.

18. Locke 1971, pp. 54ff. offers a similar example.

19. An anonymous referee raises the following further question: assume that a subject has an experiential memory and takes the experience into account when judging about the past. Are there any particular features of the relevant experience which provide the subject with a reason to make relevant judgements about the past? According to one possible view (put forward by the anonymous referee), experiential memories might have certain qualitative characteristics which provide the subject with a reason to make relevant judgements. This view, however, seems problematic for various reasons (which I discuss in Debus [manuscript]). On my own alternative view (developed in Debus [2008]), a subject who has an experiential memory of a certain object or event is directly aware of the relevant past object or event; that is, the experiential memory presents the experiencing subject with the relevant past object or event itself. According to such a “direct realist” or “relational” account of experiential memory, the relevant past object or event is a constitutive part of the experiential memory, which is, in turn, a feature of the experience which does give the subject reason to make relevant judgements about the past based on it. However, such a relational account of experiential memory might itself be rather contentious, and it is therefore important to note that none of the arguments of the present paper depend on its truth.

20. The present paper develops the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition for the case of *experiential* memory. Furthermore, although there is no room to develop the relevant arguments here, it seems quite plausible to accept that in order for a present event to count as a case of *factual* memory, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition does, *mutatis mutandis*, also have to be met.

21. David 1993, p. 111.

22. *Ibid.*

23. Notwithstanding the present comments, an anonymous referee objects that the stipulation advocated here *is* theoretically irrelevant. At first sight this might seem a surprising reaction, given the comments in the text above, but the referee’s objection might be developed as follows: once we have stipulated

that only events which have epistemic relevance for the subject should count as instances of remembering, our future usage of the word “memory” will be guided by that stipulation. Our stipulation will therefore have an impact on our future understanding of the phenomenon to which we are trying to refer with the help of the word “memory.” Thus, our stipulation does have theoretical relevance but, so the opponent will say, *each and every* stipulation will have “theoretical relevance” in the present way. For once we have stipulated that we want to use a certain word in a certain way, our future usages of the relevant word will be guided by that stipulation, which in turn means that our stipulation will have an impact on our future understanding of the phenomenon to which we are trying to refer with the help of the relevant word. But then, so the opponent will conclude, as this is the case with respect to any stipulation one might possibly want to make, the considerations adduced in the text above only show that the present stipulation is theoretically relevant in a *trivial* way, which means that it is not really theoretically relevant in any appropriate sense at all. In reply, we might indeed agree with the opponent that with respect to *any* stipulation, once we have stipulated that we want to use a certain word in a certain way, our future usages of the relevant word will be guided by that stipulation, which in turn means that our stipulation will have an impact on our future understanding of the phenomenon to which we are trying to refer with the help of the relevant word. However, so we might hold against the opponent, this does *not* mean that the theoretical relevance which the relevant stipulation plays in this respect is *trivial*. Quite on the contrary, if a stipulation influences and guides our future investigation of a certain phenomenon, the relevant stipulation does play an important role for our understanding of the phenomenon, and therefore does have theoretical relevance, which is anything but trivial.

24. Indeed, it is probably this feature of our everyday concept of memory which has prompted some philosophers to claim that to remember something *just is* to have retained knowledge about the relevant thing. Cf., e.g., Ryle 1990, chap. VIII, sec. 7; Squires 1969, p.185 (“memory is essentially the retention of knowledge”); and Bennett and Hacker 2003, p. 159 (“memory . . . is knowledge *retained*”).

25. Such a “special explanation” might be appropriate in cases where the subject knows that her experiential memories present the past in systematically distorted ways. The subject might, for example, know that her experiential memories regularly present the color of past objects as somewhat fainter than her original perceptual experience of the relevant objects truthfully presented them as being. Having an experiential memory which presents her with a light blue car approaching, this subject can then come to conclude that there was a dark blue car approaching and that she perceived a dark blue car approaching at the time.

26. Note that I do *not* aim to defend the idea that once we add the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition to the three conditions as formulated by the Causal Theory of Memory, we have a set of *sufficient* conditions for an experience to count as an experiential memory. Rather, the present paper only aims to show that in order for an experience to count as an experiential memory, the Epistemic-Relevance-Condition has to be met, which implies that the Causal-Theory’s Sufficiency-Claim is wrong.

27. Davidson 2001 is the *locus classicus* for the claim that reason-giving relations are anomalous (as well as the more general claim that the mental is anomalous). Recently, Wedgwood 2007, Pt. II, has defended the specific claim that it is impossible to offer a reductive account of normative relations.

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